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WITH 12 STARTERS RETURNING, EAGLES APPEAR READY TO FLY

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It's not common for a team coming off a 5-6 season to have realistic designs on winning the league title, but with 12 returning starters and a newfound dedication to the weight room, Oak Park High's football team has reason for optimism.

``We're ready to win,'' said David Levy, a team captain and starting offensive guard/defensive end. ``This group of seniors has grown up together, and this team is really close.

``We have a new strength and conditioning coach, and everybody has been hitting the weight room. You can see the difference already in our practices.''

The Eagles, who finished third in the Tri-Valley League last season and lost to Valley Christian in the first round of the CIF Division X playoffs, will open up their offense more this season, behind third-year starting quarterback Nate Elder and a strong receiving corps of senior Chris Adams, juniors Jason Adams and Chad Kessler and senior tight end Scott Jones.

Josh Walker, who quarterbacked the junior varsity team last season, will get some time as an option quarterback and give the Eagles a different look on offense.

``We're going to be able to do some different things on offense,'' coach Dick Billingsley said. ``We have a pretty experienced offensive line as well, so we should be able to both run and pass with efficiency.''

The running game was hurt last week when Adam Messinger, a third-year varsity player at running back, broke his wrist in practice.

``Obviously, Adam is one of the best players on our team,'' Levy said. ``When he went down, I kind of gathered the team around and said, `We lost a great player, one of our leaders, but somebody is just going to have to step up.' ''

With less than two weeks before their season opener against El Segundo, the Eagles are now forced to break in two new running backs, juniors Danny Peters and Eric Testan, to replace Messinger.

``Both of those guys are looking good, especially Eric right now,'' Billingsley said. ``Hopefully we will be able to maintain a balanced attack, but if we can't get it done on the ground we may have to open it up a little bit.''

St. Bonaventure, last year's Tri-Valley League champion, as well as Oak Park and Carpinteria, are expected to battle for the league title. The Eagles' defensive effort will be key in determining their ability to achieve their goal.

The Eagles return two starters on the defensive line, two at linebacker and two in the secondary, and Billingsley is pleased with the team's depth and his ability to fill holes in his defensive lineup when necessary.

Levy, senior defensive tackle Josh Fuks, and Anthony Giangregorio, a senior who has been moved from outside linebacker to inside linebacker, will provide the leadership for the defense.

``I think we are a lot stronger team,'' Levy said. ``We've always been one of the quicker teams in the league, but now we are looking to be one of the stronger teams. The attitude is much better as well.''

The absence of Messinger will also affect the defense, where he was the starting free safety, but again the team will be helped by depth. Billingsley is looking at three players, juniors Jesse Gabriel and Mike Williams and sophomore Monte McNair, as replacements at free safety.

The Eagles' schedule will test them early and often. Oak Park opens the season Sept. 9 at El Segundo, followed by road games against Calabasas (Sept. 17) and Orange Lutheran (Sept. 23), three tough games away from home.

``I think it will be good for us,'' Levy said. ``All three of those games are going to give us a challenge and get us prepared for league.''

Oak Park's two biggest league games are also on the road, against St. Bonaventure (Oct. 16) and the season-ender at Carpinteria on Nov. 12, but Billingsley anticipates the challenge.

``This is the most fun I've had coaching in a number of years,'' Billingsley said. ``We have some real quality coaches, and the kids have had some great practices.''

OAK PARK EAGLES

Coach: Dick Billingsley

'98 record: 5-6 (third in Tri-Valley League)

Key returners: QB Nate Elder; TE/DB Scott Jones; ILB Anthony Giangregorio; WR/DB Chris Adams; DT Josh Fuks

Top newcomers: QB Josh Walker; RB Danny Peters; RB Eric Testan; DB Jesse Gabriel

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